

FACILITATOR COPY

Contains answer keys and grading guidance. Do not publish to students.



Optima Academy Online
An Education Experience Company

Teacher Manual: College Counseling, Critical Thinking & Study Skills

Florida Course 1700370 · High School (Grade 11, college-preparatory) · One Semester · 0.5 Elective Credit · Asynchronous On-Demand, also offered live on Optima's VR campus

How to use this manual. This is a standalone facilitator reference. It is not part of the student-facing course and should never be shared with students or posted anywhere in Canvas where students can see it. It documents the course exactly as built in 03_Build (six modules: Introduction, Majors & Careers, Colleges, Money, Applying, College Essay), read directly from the built lesson pages and each module's module-N-canvas-native-items.md spec.

M365 file-naming convention (confirmed across the build): student deliverables saved to OneDrive follow LastName_<Artifact> — e.g. LastName_NetPriceFundingPlan, LastName_Resume, LastName_AngleBrainstorm, LastName_StoryDraft.

Rubric convention: every Tier 3 project is scored on the same 4-criterion, 25-point course rubric (module-specific first-criterion wording changes; the other three stay fixed). Every Tier 2 discussion is scored on the same 3-criterion, 6-point rubric.

Where facts in this manual came from: all six module-N-canvas-native-items.md specs (read in full), the resume project's resume-project-canvas-items.md, every module's lesson set and module map, and _BUILD-CONVENTIONS.md. Anything not directly confirmed by one of those files is marked **[VERIFY]**.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. How This Course Works — typical lesson, typical week, major assessments
2. Ungraded Interactives & the Intro/Outro Wrappers
3. AI & VR in This Course (Student-Facing)
4. Using Ignite AI to Support Students (Teacher-Facing)
5. Grading Categories & Canvas Gradebook Setup
6. Rubrics for Every Teacher-Graded Item

7. Discussions, Quizzes & Interactive/Assessment Activities
8. Coach, Not Catch
9. Weekly Announcement Scripts
10. Teacher Workflow & Workload Map
11. 10a. Adapting to a Live, 4-Day-a-Week Course
12. Standards Coverage Map
13. What Makes This Course Classical & Cultivating Culture
14. Sensitive-Content Flags & Family/Student Scripts

1 How This Course Works

1.1 A typical lesson

Every lesson HTML follows the standard Optima interactive-lesson anatomy (per this course's `_BUILD-CONVENTIONS.md`): a metadata strip, a title strip, an Essential Question framing, then teaching content organized as 1–2 blocks with a prominent inline HTML/CSS visual (roadmap, ladder, matrix, or comparison table — never a stock image), interleaved with 1–2 widgets drawn from a rotating engine set: a reflective check-in with no wrong answer early in the lesson, then an evaluative single-select, scale, or flip-card widget after the teaching it tests. Two of a module's three lessons carry a factual "Where AI Helps, and Where It Does Not" callout (orange, Odyssey Orange #F78F1E); the middle, more conceptual lesson in each module typically does not. The lesson closes with a numbered "What You'll Do Next (in Canvas)" list linking to that lesson's graded items.

WHAT TO TELL A NEW FACILITATOR

The lesson page itself is never gradable. Nothing on it is submitted or scored; its widgets give the student immediate feedback and reset freely. The gradebook touchpoints are the separate, Canvas-native quizzes, discussions, and assignments linked from the bottom of each lesson.

1.2 A typical module week

SEGMENT	WHAT THE STUDENT DOES	GRADED?	TIER
Opening Check-In	A short survey: essential-question guess, goals for the module, a confidence rating.	Completion only	Tier 4
Two content lessons + quizzes	Reads two lessons, each paired with a short auto-graded quiz (multiple choice, true/false, matching).	Yes, auto-scored	Tier 1
Third lesson + Discussion	Reads the module's third lesson, then posts and replies to a specific-prompt discussion.	Yes, rubric-scored	Tier 2
Module project	Completes the module's one substantive, teacher-reviewed deliverable (Word or Excel via M365).	Yes, rubric-scored	Tier 3
Wrap-Up Reflection	A closing survey: essential question revisited, confidence rating, what's unclear, a virtue reflection.	Completion only	Tier 4

Modules 5 and 6 add a project-specific track alongside this pattern: Module 5 runs the five-step Resume project (five completion check-ins + a 60-second Resume Pitch Recording + one teacher-reviewed Final Resume) in parallel with its own three lessons; Module 6 adds two completion-graded drafting steps (Angle Brainstorm, Story Draft) ahead of the Final College Essay, which itself requires a graded revision. Module 1 carries a fourth lesson, "How Memory Works" (encoding/storage/retrieval study strategies), with its own third auto-graded quiz.

1.3 Major assessments

MODULE	ASSESSMENT	TIER	WHAT IT ASKS	GRADING TIME
1 · Introduction	Personal Stock Inventory	3	An honest self-assessment of interests, strengths, and readiness (Word).	≈10–12 min/student

2 · Majors & Careers	Career & Major Exploration	3	A comparison of career-first vs. major-first paths grounded in real labor-market data (Word).	≈10–12 min/student
3 · Colleges	College Shortlist	3	A shortlist of colleges matched to genuine fit, not prestige (Word).	≈10–12 min/student
4 · Money	Net Price & Funding Plan	3	A real net-price-calculator result and a funding plan across grants/scholarships/earned/loans (Excel).	≈12–15 min/student
5 · Applying	College Application Tracker	1 (completion)	A working spreadsheet of every target college's deadlines and requirements (Excel).	≈3–5 min/student (spot-check)
5 · Applying (Resume project)	Final Resume	3	A one-page resume built through the five-step brainstorm-to-design process (Word).	≈12–15 min/student
6 · College Essay	Final College Essay + required revision	3	A complete personal essay for a Common App prompt, graded once, revised from feedback, and graded again.	≈15–18 min/student, twice

2 Ungraded Interactives & the Intro/Outro Wrappers

Two things new facilitators most often misunderstand:

2.1 The lesson-embedded widgets

The reflective and evaluative widgets built into every lesson (Section 1.1) produce no submission and need no grading. They are formation-by-practice, not busywork to chase. A student who skips them shows up indirectly, in quiz and assignment performance, not as a missing grade. They cost the facilitator zero hours.

2.2 The Opening/Wrap-Up wrappers are Canvas survey quizzes, not pages

Every module's Opening Check-In and Wrap-Up Reflection are built as Canvas Quizzes in survey mode — not wiki pages — so responses become sortable cohort data: essential-question guesses, confidence ratings, "what's still unclear," and a virtue reflection. The highest-leverage move in this course is **spending 15–20 minutes per module triaging Wrap-Up responses** before moving to the next module. Look for: confidence clusters below 3/5, the same unclear concept named by several students, and virtue-reflection answers that hint at struggle (e.g. a student naming "the loan number scared me" in Module 4, or "I didn't want to write about it" in Module 6). Act on what you find with a targeted announcement (Section 9), an Ignite AI-drafted nudge (Section 4), or a direct message — not a grade penalty.

3 AI & VR in This Course (Student-Facing)

3.1 AI

The course's posture, read from its own callouts, is awareness and verification, not required tool use. Every module but the middle, conceptual lesson carries a factual "Where AI Helps, and Where It Does Not" callout naming what AI can support (formatting, organizing categories, listing career fields, suggesting candidate schools) and what it cannot replace (deciding your own values, recalling your own life, writing in your own voice, guaranteeing current facts). A second, recurring thread runs through Modules 2–4: **verify AI-suggested facts against the real source** — O*NET/BLS for career data, the college's own site and College Scorecard for school facts, studentaid.gov and net price calculators for cost figures. Module 6 states plainly that AI-generated essays are not accepted; one of its auto-graded quiz questions tests why (readers increasingly notice, and it does not sound like the student). Do not add new AI requirements beyond what is already built.

3.2 VR

This course's own lessons do not include a built VR activity this pass (a deliberate scope decision during the 2026 revision, made because Optima was mid-transition between VR platforms). What the course does carry is the same general Optima VR-campus presence every course does: live sections meet on the VR campus, and On-Demand scholars can attend the weekly study hall and VR workshops there. If a facilitator wants to add a VR component to a Live section in the future, keep it platform-agnostic and describe it by what the student does, not by naming a specific platform.

4 Using Ignite AI to Support Students (Teacher-Facing)

[VERIFY] Ignite AI's exact feature names and availability vary by Canvas release and by what Optima has enabled. Confirm the current feature set against Optima's Canvas instance before promising a specific button to a new facilitator.

Used well, Ignite AI is what makes 500:1 feel personal. Five functional uses for this course specifically:

- **Drafting individualized feedback.** Especially valuable on Module 4's Net Price & Funding Plan and Module 6's Final Essay, where feedback needs to be specific to one student's real numbers or real story — let Ignite AI draft a first pass, then you edit and own it.
- **Summarizing Wrap-Up wrapper analytics** to find the cohort's sticking points fast (Section 2.2) before the next module opens.
- **Surfacing students who need a nudge** — low confidence on a Wrap-Up, a missed College Application Tracker, declining quiz performance — and drafting a warm check-in message.
- **Generating practice variants** for a student who needs another rep on a Tier 1 quiz topic (e.g. sticker price vs. net price in Module 4, or SAT/ACT/CLT differences in Module 5).
- **Communicating with families** about cost and application planning in clear, kind language, and translating messages when helpful.

AI drafts, the teacher decides. Read, edit, and own anything before it reaches a student or family. Never use analytics or AI to surveil, rank, or auto-penalize (Section 8).

5 Grading Categories & Canvas Gradebook Setup

5.1 Grading categories (assignment groups)

ASSIGNMENT GROUP	WEIGHT	MAPS TO
Practice & Comprehension	55%	Tier 1 auto-graded quizzes and completion-graded steps
Discussions & Reflections	25%	Tier 2 discussions
Major Projects	15%	Tier 3 teacher-reviewed projects
Wrappers & Participation	5%	Tier 4 survey quizzes (completion/participation credit)

5.2 Step-by-step Canvas setup

1. Create the four assignment groups above under Grades > view group weights.
2. Set group weights to 55/25/15/5 and confirm "Weight final grade based on assignment groups" is on.
3. Mark every Opening Check-In and Wrap-Up Reflection as a **survey quiz** (Quiz type > Ungraded Survey, or Graded Survey with 0 points if you want it to appear in the gradebook as complete/incomplete).
4. Set the five Resume step check-ins and Module 6's Angle Brainstorm/Story Draft to **Complete/Incomplete** grading, not points-based.
5. Late/missing policy: per the course syllabus, no per-due-date penalty; unsubmitted work at semester's end scores zero, and anything submitted in the final 14 days receives a 10% deduction. Set this under Course Settings > Grading Policies if your Canvas instance supports it, or apply manually near semester's end.
6. Use the Module Progress / requirements view for an at-a-glance completion signal across all the ungraded/completion scaffolding.

5.3 Gradebook map

MODULE	ITEM	GROUP	POINTS/WEIGHT	METHOD
MODULE 1 · INTRODUCTION				
1	Opening Check-In	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
1	How This Course Works (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
1	Higher Education Basics (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
1	Memory Strategies (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
1	College Myths Discussion	Discussions & Reflections	6 pts	Rubric
1	Personal Stock Inventory	Major Projects	25 pts	Rubric
1	Wrap-Up Reflection	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
MODULE 2 · MAJORS & CAREERS				
2	Opening Check-In	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
2	Career Fields & Degrees (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto

2	Majors & Skills (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
2	Career-First or Major-First Discussion	Discussions & Reflections	6 pts	Rubric
2	Career & Major Exploration	Major Projects	25 pts	Rubric
2	Wrap-Up Reflection	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
MODULE 3 • COLLEGES				
3	Opening Check-In	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
3	Finding Strong Programs (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
3	Types of Colleges (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
3	Fit over Prestige Discussion	Discussions & Reflections	6 pts	Rubric
3	College Shortlist	Major Projects	25 pts	Rubric
3	Wrap-Up Reflection	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
MODULE 4 • MONEY				
4	Opening Check-In	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
4	The Real Cost of College (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈12 pts	Auto
4	Free Money, Borrowed Money (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈14 pts	Auto
4	Sticker Shock Discussion	Discussions & Reflections	6 pts	Rubric
4	Net Price & Funding Plan	Major Projects	25 pts	Rubric
4	Wrap-Up Reflection	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
MODULE 5 • APPLYING (+ RESUME PROJECT)				
5	Opening Check-In	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
5	Applications & Organization (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
5	College Application Tracker	Practice & Comprehension	Completion	Completion
5	Admissions Testing (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈8 pts	Auto
5	Which Test Fits You? Discussion	Discussions & Reflections	6 pts	Rubric
5	Resume Steps 1–5 (five check-ins)	Practice & Comprehension	5 pts each	Completion
5	Resume Pitch Recording (60-sec audio/video)	Practice & Comprehension	5 pts	Completion
5	Final Resume	Major Projects	25 pts	Rubric
5	Wrap-Up Reflection	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
MODULE 6 • COLLEGE ESSAY				
6	Opening Check-In	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey
6	Essay Foundations (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈10 pts	Auto
6	Angle Brainstorm	Practice & Comprehension	Completion	Completion
6	Essay Angles Discussion	Discussions & Reflections	6 pts	Rubric
6	Story Draft	Practice & Comprehension	Completion	Completion

6	Common App & Essay Types (quiz)	Practice & Comprehension	≈8 pts	Auto
6	Final College Essay (+ required revision)	Major Projects	25 pts	Rubric, twice
6	Wrap-Up Reflection	Wrappers & Participation	Completion	Survey

6 Rubrics for Every Teacher-Graded Item

[VERIFY note, not a gap] Every one of this course's Tier 1 quizzes is fully auto-scored (multiple choice, true/false, matching) — there are no manually-graded free-response quiz questions anywhere in the build. The Wrap-Up wrapper surveys include short-answer and essay prompts, but per the build these are graded on completion only, never on content, so no answer guide is needed for them.

6.1 Standard module-project rubric (Tier 3, 25 pts) — used in every module

CRITERION (PTS)	EXCELLENT (4)	PROFICIENT (3)	DEVELOPING (2)	BEGINNING (1)
Module-specific first criterion (7 pts) — e.g. "Understanding of self" (M1), "Understanding of fit" (M3), "Understanding of costs" (M4)	Deep, specific, evidence-based	Solid, minor gaps	Partly guessed or generic	Largely absent
Quality of reasoning (6 pts)	Specific, well-ordered, justified	Mostly specific	Generic, unsupported	Disconnected from the work
Completeness (6 pts)	All required parts present and reconciled	Minor gaps	Several gaps	Largely incomplete
Clarity & honesty (6 pts)	Readable, labeled, genuinely reflective	Clear, mostly honest	Hard to follow or generic	Unclear or missing reflection

Module 6's Final College Essay uses a parallel 4-criterion/25-point rubric with essay-specific criteria (Angle & story 7 pts · Insight & reflection 6 · Craft & clarity 6 · Authenticity & honesty 6) — see Section 7.2 for the full table. The Final Resume uses its own parallel version (Audience fit 7 · Quality of content 6 · Design & readability 6 · Clarity & correctness 6).

6.2 Standard discussion rubric (Tier 2, 6 pts) — used in every module

CRITERION	FULL (2)	PARTIAL (1)	MISSING (0)
Substance (names a real fact/choice/college with specifics)	Specific and accurate	Vague or unsourced	Absent
Reasoning (ties the choice to real evidence)	Clear, supported connection	Asserted only	Absent
Reply to a classmate	Substantive, specific	Thin ("nice idea")	Absent

Paste each rubric into its Canvas item as a native Canvas Rubric so it scores in SpeedGrader.

7 Discussions, Quizzes & Interactive/Assessment Activities

7.1 General guidance by type

- **Auto-graded quiz (Tier 1):** multiple choice/true-false/matching, self-scoring, no facilitator time. Spot-check for item drift each semester.
- **Completion assignment (Tier 1):** the Resume steps, College Application Tracker, Angle Brainstorm, and Story Draft. Mark complete on submission; spot-check in batches; save deep feedback for the paired Tier 3 item.
- **Structured discussion (Tier 2):** read in batches; drop 2–3 public model comments naming real student insight; grade on the 3-criterion rubric (Section 6.2).
- **Reflection/wrapper survey (Tier 4):** completion credit; the real value is triaging the analytics (Section 2.2), not grading content.
- **Teacher-reviewed project (Tier 3):** the one deep-feedback touchpoint per module; grade on the standard rubric (Section 6.1); flag one strength and one growth edge in every comment.

7.2 Per-instance grading notes

MODULE	ITEM	TYPE	TIER	HOW TO GRADE THIS ONE
1	College Myths Discussion	Discussion	2	Full credit needs a real named myth vs. reality and a reply that engages a classmate's specific point.
1	Personal Stock Inventory	Assignment	3	First criterion = "Understanding of self." Note 2–3 accomplishments/traits that could seed a Module 5 resume bullet or a Module 6 essay angle — this feeds forward.
2	Career-First or Major-First Discussion	Discussion	2	Look for a real O*NET/BLS data point, not just a stated preference.
2	Career & Major Exploration	Assignment	3	First criterion = choices clearly grounded in specific inventory evidence and real labor-market data.
3	Fit over Prestige Discussion	Discussion	2	Full credit distinguishes a fit factor (program, culture, support) from a prestige signal (ranking, selectivity).
3	College Shortlist	Assignment	3	First criterion = "Understanding of fit." Watch for a shortlist built entirely from name-brand recognition with no fit reasoning.
4	Sticker Shock Discussion	Discussion	2	Requires a real college's real published cost of attendance, not an estimate. Reminder embedded in the prompt: no family financial details (Section 13).
4	Net Price & Funding Plan	Assignment	3	Watch for real family income anywhere in the submission (should be \$0-entered per instructions) — see Section 13's script before treating this as a violation. Flag one funding line that's stronger than the student thinks and one guess dressed as fact.
5	Which Test Fits You? Discussion	Discussion	2	Full credit ties test choice (or test-optional) to a specific test feature and a specific personal strength or target-college policy.
5	Resume Pitch Recording	Assignment (media)	1	Completion only: a genuine ~60-second spoken pitch in the student's own voice. If a submission is clearly rushed or unrelated, ask for a

resubmission rather than marking incomplete (coach, not catch).

5	Final Resume	Assignment	3	Flag the two strongest bullet lines in your comments — these often become Module 6 essay-angle candidates.
6	Essay Angles Discussion	Discussion	2	Full credit names one focused story/idea, not several unfocused options.
6	Final College Essay	Assignment	3, twice	The required revision is where the grade is earned. Give 2–3 specific, story-level comments on the first submission; grade the revision.

8 Coach, Not Catch

Your job is to move each student forward, not to detect and punish. In practice:

- Feedback names the next step, not just the error. Lead with what's working.
- Allow re-attempts on Tier 1 quizzes; they are a learning tool, not a trap.
- Use Wrap-Up analytics and Ignite AI to find students who need help early, then reach out — not to build a case against them.
- On suspected AI misuse (a Module 6 essay that doesn't sound like the student, generic filler on a reflection): open a conversation, ask the student to talk through their thinking, treat it as formation, not an accusation.
- **Built-in course example:** if a student's Module 4 Net Price & Funding Plan shows real family financial figures instead of the required \$0-entry privacy version, the build's own teacher note says to quietly ask for a resubmission with the privacy-protected version — not to flag it as an integrity violation. That is coach-not-catch in practice.
- Public discussion comments model good thinking; they never single out weak work for criticism.

9 Weekly Announcement Scripts

9.1 Reusable template

[MODULE N] TEMPLATE

Hi everyone — we're in [Module N: Name] this [week/stretch]. This module asks you to [one-line focus]. The one thing not to miss: [due major assessment or tricky concept] by [due date]. [One warm, specific line of encouragement, e.g. naming something you saw students do well last module].

9.2 Drafted scripts, one per module

- **Module 1 — Introduction:** Welcome to the course. This module is about taking honest stock of where you are before we plan anything. The Personal Stock Inventory is due [date] — it becomes the foundation for your resume and essay later this semester, so real effort here pays off twice.
- **Module 2 — Majors & Careers:** This module compares two ways to choose a path: starting from a career, or starting from a major. Use real O*NET/BLS data, not guesses. Career & Major Exploration is due [date].
- **Module 3 — Colleges:** Time to build your shortlist. The goal is fit, not brand names — program strength, size, culture, and support services all matter. College Shortlist is due [date], and it closes out Quarter 1.
- **Module 4 — Money:** This module asks for honesty about numbers that can feel uncomfortable. Run a real net price calculator for one target college. Remember: enter \$0 for family financial info in your submitted version — run the real numbers privately for your own planning. Net Price & Funding Plan due [date].
- **Module 5 — Applying:** Two things running in parallel this module: getting organized (tracker, testing) and building your resume, one step at a time. Don't skip a resume step even if it feels rough — each one feeds the next. Final Resume due [date].
- **Module 6 — College Essay:** Find your angle first, don't outline five paragraphs. Your essay will get feedback and a required revision, so the first draft doesn't have to be perfect — it has to be honestly yours. AI-generated essays are not accepted. Final Essay due [date], revision due [date].

9.3 Situational scripts

- **Mid-module check-in:** If your confidence on the last Wrap-Up was low, that's normal and worth a message — reply here or come to office hours and we'll work through it together.
- **Pre-major-assessment reminder:** [Assessment name] is due [date]. Before you submit, reread the rubric criteria in the assignment description — most points are lost on completeness, not effort.
- **Re-engagement nudge (quiet students):** I haven't seen a submission from you in a bit — everything okay? Reply here or message me; there's always a way back on track.

10 Teacher Workflow & Workload Map

10.1 A normal week

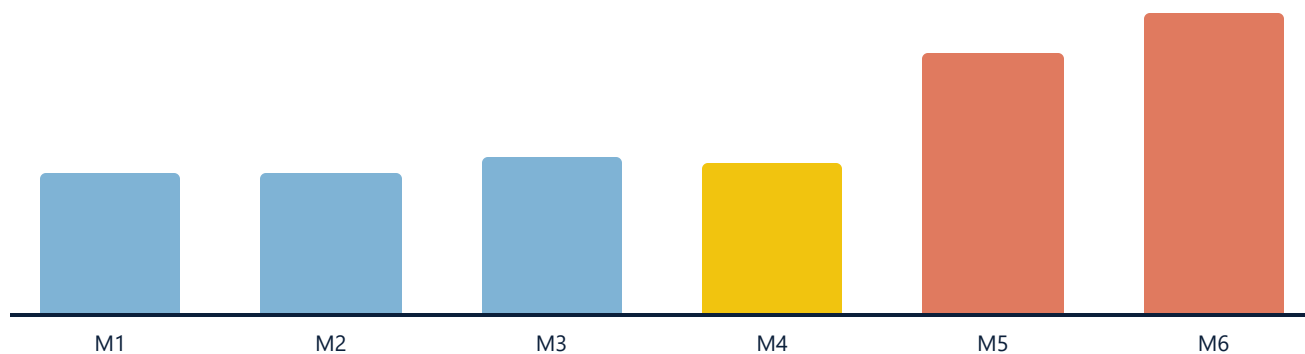
1. Triage the most recent Wrap-Up wrapper analytics (15–20 min).
2. Grade that module's discussion in a batch, dropping 2–3 public model comments (30–45 min per ~30 students).
3. Grade that module's Tier 3 project on the standard rubric (Section 6.1) — the heaviest single task most modules.
4. Post the module announcement (Section 9).
5. Answer student messages and hold office hours / study hall.

Time budget per module (per optima-canvas-assignments): ≈0h on Tier 1 (auto/completion), 2–3h on Tier 2 discussions, 8–12h on the Tier 3 project, spread across the module for a ~30-student section.

10.2 Heavy modules to plan around

- **Module 5 (Applying + Resume):** carries both the module's own Tier 3 (none separately — the Resume *is* the project) plus five completion check-ins, the Resume Pitch Recording, and a tracker to spot-check. More individual touchpoints than any other module.
- **Module 6 (College Essay):** the course capstone. The Final Essay is graded **twice** — once on the first submission, once on the required revision — making it the heaviest single grading load in the course. Budget roughly double the usual Tier 3 time here.

10.3 Workload-fluctuation graphic



Relative facilitator-grading load by module. Blue = standard, gold = standard with a sensitive-content watch item, coral = heavy (extra touchpoints or double grading). Plan extra time on the coral modules.

10a Adapting to a Live, 4-Day-a-Week Course

This course was built async, but the same content maps onto a live, 4-day-a-week class without rewriting anything. Week numbers below match the sample fall-semester pacing in this course's syllabus (Module 1–3 = 3 weeks each, Module 4 = 2 weeks, Module 5 = 4 weeks, Module 6 = 3 weeks); treat this as a starting template, not a fixed schedule — shift it whenever a real class needs more or less time.

10a.1 The 4-day live template (applied once per lesson)

DAY	MAPS TO (ASYNC CONTENT)	WHAT HAPPENS LIVE
Day 1	Essential Question + lesson's opening content + reflective widget	Open with the week's essential question as a live discussion; introduce the lesson's core idea.
Day 2	Core teaching content + evaluative widget + AI-awareness callout (where present)	Teach the concept directly; where the lesson has a "Where AI Helps" callout, run it as a live conversation about verifying facts.
Day 3	The Tier 2 discussion prompt or Tier 3 project work	The discussion prompt becomes a live conversation instead of (or in addition to) a Canvas post; in a module's final week, this is project build/work time with the teacher circulating.
Day 4	The Tier 1 quiz + wrap-up	Students finish and submit the quiz; short live wrap-up before moving on.

10a.2 Week-by-week live schedule

WK	FOCUS	DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	ADAPTATION TIP
MODULE 1 · INTRODUCTION						
1	Course Intro	How-this-course-works hook + Opening Check-In live	Walk the syllabus and grading live	Live Q&A on expectations	How This Course Works quiz	Use Day 3 to surface real questions about pacing before students are on their own.
2	Understanding Higher Education	Major-vs-career hook	Degree types + college myths teaching	College Myths Discussion, live	Higher Education Basics quiz	Run "myth vs. reality" as a live show-of-hands before revealing the facts.
3	Taking Personal Stock + How Memory Works	Self-assessment framing + guided writing time	Build the Personal Stock Inventory in class	How Memory Works taught live (encoding/spacing/retrieval; run the reread-vs-self-quiz contrast as a live demo)	Memory Strategies quiz + Wrap-Up Reflection	Keep Days 1–2 quiet and individual; self-assessment doesn't work as a group

activity. Day 3's memory lesson pays forward: name it again before every quiz this semester.

MODULE 2 • MAJORS & CAREERS

4	Start With the Career	Career-first hook	O*NET/BLS live data-lookup demo	Career Fields & Degrees quiz review live	Career Fields & Degrees quiz	Have students look up one real career's O*NET page live on Day 2.
5	Start With the Major	Major-first hook + hard/soft skills	Salary-comparison teaching	Majors & Skills quiz review	Majors & Skills quiz	Compare starting vs. mid-career salary live using a real BLS table.
6	Matching You to a Field	Self-assessment recap (ties to Module 1)	Guided matching exercise	Career-First or Major-First Discussion, live	Career & Major Exploration project work + Wrap-Up	Let students argue both sides live before they commit to their own project direction.

MODULE 3 • COLLEGES

7	Finding Schools That Fit	College Scorecard hook	Live program-research demo	Practice looking up 2–3 real schools	Finding Strong Programs quiz	Do the Scorecard walkthrough live so no one gets lost in the tool alone.
8	Types of Colleges	Public/private/2-yr/4-yr hook	Trade-offs teaching (size, distance, culture)	Types of Colleges quiz review	Types of Colleges quiz	A quick sort-the-college-type activity works well as a Day 1 opener.
9	Other Considerations	Fit-vs-prestige framing	Support-services research time	Fit over Prestige Discussion, live	College Shortlist project work + Wrap-Up (Q1 ends)	Close Quarter 1 with a short live share-out of one shortlist school each.

MODULE 4 • MONEY

10	What College Costs	Sticker price vs. net price hook	Reading a real college bill, live	Sticker Shock Discussion, live (no family financial details)	The Real Cost of College quiz	Model looking up one real college's cost
----	--------------------	----------------------------------	-----------------------------------	--	-------------------------------	--

of attendance
live before the
discussion.

11	Ways to Pay + FAFSA/Net Price/Borrowing	Free-earned- borrowed order hook	Live net price calculator demo (privacy rule modeled explicitly)	Funding-plan work time	Free Money, Borrowed Money quiz + Net Price & Funding Plan due + Wrap- Up	Demonstrate the \$0-entry privacy version live so every student sees the expected format before submitting.
----	---	--	--	------------------------	---	--

MODULE 5 · APPLYING (+ RESUME)

12	Getting Organized + Application Tracker	Application-parts hook	Live tracker- building demo	Build own tracker in class	Applications & Organization quiz	Have every student's tracker skeleton built by end of Day 3.
13	Inside an Application + Admissions Testing	SAT/ACT/CLT hook	Compare test formats live	Which Test Fits You? Discussion, live	Admissions Testing quiz	A practice- section sampler (one question from each test) works well on Day 2.
14	Resume Steps 1–2 (Brainstorm, Read Your Audience)	Brainstorm live, whole class	Target- audience research time	Peer-share keyword lists	Submit Steps 1–2	The brainstorm step works best as a fast, low- pressure live freewrite.
15	Resume Steps 3–5 (Overlap, Draft, Design) + Bringing It Together	Overlap demo live	Draft-writing time	Design-pass peer feedback, live	Final Resume due + deliver the 60- second Resume Pitch live (recording submitted to Canvas) + Wrap-Up	Run a live skim-test exchange (10- second look, one reaction) before finalizing. In a live section, the pitch works best delivered to a partner before recording.

MODULE 6 · COLLEGE ESSAY

16	Why Write It Yourself + Find Your Angle	Why-AI-essays- fail hook	Live angle- brainstorming	Angle Brainstorm work time	Essay Foundations quiz	Share 2–3 real (anonymized) angle examples
----	---	-----------------------------	------------------------------	----------------------------	------------------------------	--

live to spark ideas.

17	Tell the Story + Reflection/Why This College	Opening-line workshop	Live story-drafting time	Essay Angles Discussion, live	Story Draft due	Read 2–3 strong opening lines aloud (anonymized) as a Day 1 model.
18	Common App & Drafting	Word-limit/prompt-types hook	Full-draft workshop, live	Peer feedback exchange	Common App & Essay Types quiz + Final Essay due (revision due the following week)	Hold a short individual conference slot on Day 3 for every student before the deadline.

11 Standards Coverage Map

Course-title note. The official, state-approved CPALMS title for Florida course #1700370 is "**Critical Thinking and Study Skills**" (Subject: Research and Critical Thinking; Abbreviated Title: CRIT THINK ST SKLS; half credit; one semester; Grades 9–12) — not "College Counseling, Critical Thinking & Study Skills." Optima's build repurposes this generic critical-thinking/study-skills elective as a college-counseling course. That is an intentional local design choice, not an error, but whoever handles state course-code reporting should know the built content and the state's course description diverge; confirm this repurposing is acceptable under the course code before publishing at scale.

Source: College Counseling Critical Thinking and Study Skills (1700370).pdf, the official CPALMS course export saved in this course's top-level folder, generated from cpalms.org/PreviewCourse/Preview/23760. All codes and descriptions below are copied verbatim from that document, not invented.

11.1 The full official standards list for #1700370

CODE	DESCRIPTION
ELA.9.C.1.3	Write to argue a position, supporting claims with logical reasoning and credible evidence, rebutting counterclaims.
ELA.9.C.1.4	Write expository texts to explain and analyze information from multiple sources.
ELA.9.C.1.5	Improve writing by considering feedback from adults, peers, and/or online editing tools; revise for clarity and cohesiveness.
ELA.9.C.2.1	Present information orally, with logical organization, coherent focus, and credible evidence.
ELA.9.C.3.1	Follow the rules of standard English grammar, punctuation, capitalization, and spelling.
ELA.9.C.4.1	Conduct research to answer a question, drawing on multiple reliable and valid sources, refining the question's scope to match findings.
ELA.9.R.2.1	Analyze how multiple text structures and/or features convey purpose and/or meaning.
ELA.9.R.2.2	Evaluate the support an author uses to develop the central idea(s) of a text.
ELA.9.R.2.3	Analyze how an author achieves purpose through rhetorical appeals and/or figurative language.
ELA.9.R.2.4	Compare two opposing arguments on the same topic, evaluating effectiveness and validity.
ELA.9.V.1.1	Integrate grade-level academic vocabulary in speaking and writing.
ELA.9.V.1.2	Apply knowledge of etymology and derivations to determine word/phrase meanings.
ELA.9.V.1.3	Use context clues, figurative language, word relationships, and reference materials to determine connotative/denotative meaning.
ELA.K12.EE.1.1	Cite evidence to explain and justify reasoning.
ELA.K12.EE.2.1	Read and comprehend grade-level complex texts proficiently.
ELA.K12.EE.3.1	Make inferences to support comprehension.
ELA.K12.EE.4.1	Use appropriate collaborative techniques and active listening skills in discussions.
ELA.K12.EE.5.1	Use the accepted rules of a specific format to create quality work.
ELA.K12.EE.6.1	Use appropriate voice and tone when speaking or writing.

MA.K12.MTR.1.1 – 7.1	The seven Mathematical Thinking and Reasoning routines (effortful learning, multiple representations, fluency, reflective discussion, patterns/structure, reasonableness of solutions, real-world application).
SS.912.P.11.3	Discuss strategies for improving the encoding of memory.
SS.912.P.11.7	Discuss strategies for improving the storage of memories.
SS.912.P.11.12	Discuss strategies for improving the retrieval of memories.
SS.912.P.12.2	Define processes involved in problem solving and decision making.
ELD.K12.ELL.SI.1	English language learners communicate for social and instructional purposes (blanket ELD standard, satisfied via general ELL accommodations, not lesson-specific content).

11.2 By module: which real codes the built content addresses

Rows marked ♦ reflect content added 2026-07-16 in a dedicated gap-closing pass (a new Module 1 memory lesson, a Module 5 oral pitch recording, rhetorical-appeals and comparing-arguments teaching blocks retrofitted into existing M3/M2 lessons, and etymology/context-clue vocabulary grids in M4/M5).

MODULE	CODES ADDRESSED	WHERE
1 · Introduction	SS.912.P.12.2 · ELA.K12.EE.5.1 · ELA.K12.EE.6.1 · ELA.K12.EE.4.1 · ♦ SS.912.P.11.3 / .11.7 / .11.12	Personal Stock Inventory (Tier 3); College Myths Discussion (Tier 2); ♦ Lesson 1.04 "How Memory Works" + Memory Strategies quiz (encoding/storage/retrieval)
2 · Majors & Careers	ELA.9.C.4.1 · SS.912.P.12.2 · ELA.K12.EE.1.1 · ELA.K12.EE.4.1 · ♦ ELA.9.R.2.4	Career & Major Exploration (Tier 3); Career-First or Major-First Discussion (Tier 2); ♦ Lesson 2.01 Part 4 "Weighing Two Arguments" + quiz Q6
3 · Colleges	ELA.9.C.4.1 · SS.912.P.12.2 · ELA.K12.EE.1.1 · ELA.K12.EE.4.1 · ♦ ELA.9.R.2.2 / .2.3	College Shortlist (Tier 3); Fit over Prestige Discussion (Tier 2); ♦ Lesson 3.01 Part 4 "Reading a College's Own Pitch" (ethos/pathos/logos) + quiz Q6
4 · Money	MA.K12.MTR.7.1 · MA.K12.MTR.6.1 · MA.K12.MTR.2.1 · ELA.9.C.4.1 · SS.912.P.12.2 · ELA.K12.EE.4.1 · ♦ ELA.9.V.1.2 / .1.3 · MA.K12.MTR.4.1	Net Price & Funding Plan (Tier 3, the course's strongest math-standard match); Sticker Shock Discussion (Tier 2, reply prompt now asks students to compare each other's sticker-vs-net reasoning); ♦ Lesson 4.03 financial-vocabulary etymology grid
5 · Applying	ELA.K12.EE.5.1 · ELA.9.C.4.1 · ELA.K12.EE.6.1 · SS.912.P.12.2 · ELA.K12.EE.4.1 · ♦ ELA.9.C.2.1 · ELA.9.V.1.2 / .1.3	Final Resume (Tier 3); Which Test Fits You? Discussion (Tier 2); ♦ Resume Pitch Recording (60-second oral delivery); ♦ Lesson 5.03 testing-vocabulary etymology grid
6 · College Essay	ELA.9.C.1.5 · ELA.K12.EE.6.1 · ELA.9.C.1.4 · ELA.K12.EE.5.1 · ELA.K12.EE.4.1 · ELA.9.C.3.1	Final College Essay + required revision (Tier 3, the course's strongest writing-standard match); Essay Angles Discussion (Tier 2); conventions assessed via the essay rubric's "Craft & clarity" and the resume rubric's "Clarity & correctness" criteria

ELA.K12.EE.1.1 (cite evidence) and ELA.K12.EE.4.1 (collaborative discussion norms) run through every module's Tier 3 project and Tier 2 discussion respectively, since every module asks for real, sourced evidence and a post-plus-reply discussion structure.

11.3 Remaining thin spots after the 2026-07-16 gap-closing pass

The pass above closed the course's confirmed gaps: the memory-strategy trio (SS.912.P.11.3/.7/.12), oral presentation (ELA.9.C.2.1), rhetorical/argument analysis (ELA.9.R.2.2/.2.3/.2.4), etymology and context-clue vocabulary (ELA.9.V.1.2/.1.3), and conventions-as-assessed (ELA.9.C.3.1). What remains is thinner coverage that is arguably inherent to a college-counseling application of this course code rather than a fixable omission:

- **ELA.9.R.2.1** (analyzing text structures and features) — no assigned text is analyzed for structure. The College Scorecard and net-price-calculator work exercises reading informational features in practice, but nothing teaches structure analysis explicitly.
- **ELA.9.V.1.1** (integrating academic vocabulary into speaking and writing) — the new vocabulary grids teach word origins and context clues (V.1.2/.1.3 directly), and the discussions and projects give students authentic occasions to use the terms; deliberate vocabulary-integration instruction, however, is not built.
- **ELA.9.C.1.3** (argumentative writing with counterclaim rebuttal) — discussions ask for reasoned positions and fair-minded replies, but no full argumentative essay with rebuttal is assigned. The Final College Essay is narrative/reflective by design.
- **ELA.K12.EE.2.1 / .3.1** (grade-level complex text comprehension; inference) — no complex literary text is assigned; the reading load is informational (program pages, aid documents, test policies). Inference is exercised constantly but never against a complex text.
- **MA.K12.MTR.1.1, 3.1, 5.1** (effortful-learning routines, fluency, patterns/structure) — Module 4 exercises MTR.2.1/4.1/6.1/7.1; these three remaining routines describe sustained mathematical problem-solving discourse this course does not otherwise do.

These remaining items are the honest residue of running a college-counseling curriculum under a general critical-thinking/study-skills course code. Bring this section to whoever owns compliance sign-off; the practical options are (a) accept the thin spots as adequately touched for an elective, or (b) note that the B.E.S.T. EE and MTR standards are officially "embedded within the content as applicable" per the course description's own language, which is the posture this build takes.

12 What Makes This Course Classical & Cultivating Culture

12.1 What makes it classical

- **Vocation as more than a job:** the course treats choosing a path after high school as a question of what kind of life is worth building, not just an employability exercise — consistent with Optima's mission framing of purposeful vocation.
- **Evidence over secondhand claims:** every module trains students to verify against a primary source (O*NET/BLS for careers, the college's own site and College Scorecard for schools, a real net price calculator for cost, studentaid.gov for aid) rather than trusting an AI summary or a rumor. This is applied empirical discipline, not abstract "critical thinking" vocabulary.
- **Worked example, then guided practice, then independent production:** the Resume project's five-step brainstorm → audience → overlap → draft → design arc, and the Essay's angle-first → story → reflection arc, both scaffold a genuine craft rather than assigning a cold blank page.
- **A named virtue thread in every module's Wrap-Up wrapper:** Module 4 asks where the student had "to resist wishful thinking" about money; Module 5 asks where "courtesy and foresight" mattered in requesting recommendations and transcripts on time; Module 6 asks where writing honestly about oneself "took a kind of courage." Modules 1–3 carry the same virtue-reflection structure in their own Wrap-Ups.
- **Self-knowledge as a precondition for the essay:** Module 6 explicitly builds on the Module 1 Personal Stock Inventory, treating "know thyself" as literally load-bearing for the course's capstone writing, not just a nice sentiment.

12.2 Cultivating culture asynchronously

- Treat the weekly discussion as a real conversation: read every post, and actually drop the 2–3 public model comments the build repeatedly calls for, naming students by their actual insight.
- Use the Wrap-Up triage (Section 2.2) to write announcements that reference real, specific student confusion — not a generic "great work this module."
- Keep the virtue thread visible: name it in an announcement when you see a student actually practice honesty in a funding plan or courage in an essay draft, not only when the wrapper asks them to reflect on it.
- Treat feedback as relationship: the same student reads your comments on six major projects this semester (seven counting the essay's revision); consistency in tone builds the trust that makes coaching (Section 8) land.

13 Sensitive-Content Flags & Family/Student Scripts

13.1 Family financial privacy (Module 4 — Money)

Where: Module 4's Sticker Shock Discussion and Net Price & Funding Plan assignment both touch real family financial information. The build explicitly instructs students to run the net price calculator privately with real numbers for their own planning, but to submit a \$0-entry "privacy-protected estimate" version, and to never share family financial details in the discussion.

Suggested family/student script: [Teacher: personalize and send before Module 4 opens.] "In the next module, we'll talk openly about what college costs and how families typically pay for it. Your student will run a real net price calculator for practice, but the version they submit to us uses \$0 placeholders for family financial details — we never ask students to share real family income or financial information with the class or with me. If your student has questions about your own family's specific financial picture, that's a conversation to have at home; I'm glad to point toward general resources (FAFSA, scholarship search tools) any time."

13.2 Personal narrative disclosure (Module 6 — College Essay)

Where: the Final College Essay asks students to write from a genuinely personal angle — something they're proud of, care about, or that shaped them. Some students may be drawn to write about a difficult personal experience.

Suggested family/student script: [Teacher: personalize.] "The college essay project asks students to write honestly about themselves, in their own voice. Most students write about an accomplishment, an interest, or an everyday moment that reveals something real about them — a smaller number choose to write about something more difficult they've been through. Either is fine; there's no requirement to disclose anything a student isn't comfortable sharing, and I'm always available if a student wants to talk through what to include before they write."

13.3 Academic integrity note (Module 6 — AI-generated essays)

Where: the build states plainly that AI-generated essays are not accepted, and one auto-graded quiz question tests students on why. This is a stated policy rather than a "sensitive content" flag in the traditional sense, but worth a proactive family note given how common AI essay-drafting tools have become.

Suggested script: [Teacher: personalize.] "As your student works on their college essay this module, a quick note: colleges and our course both expect this essay to be the student's own writing and thinking. AI tools are welcome for brainstorming or checking grammar, but the essay itself — and the required revision — must be the student's genuine voice. If you're helping at home, feel free to talk through ideas, but let your student do the actual writing."